

LIVE



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ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

13th WEEK



TIBET & INDIAN DIPLOMACY

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... India and its Neighborhood- relations.

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Tibet is not a card

India must refresh its overseas China policy and its domestic engagement with the Tibetan community



SUJASINI SAHA

The government's bid to ease tensions with China has been met with some criticism, particularly over a leaked memo to officials telling them to stay away from events that commemorate the 60th anniversary of the Dalai Lama's 1959 flight to India. This has led to the cancellation of several public events related to Tibet. Much of the criticism stems from the perception that the government is attempting to appease China by giving up its "Tibet card". Clearly, giving in to China's aggression on the subject is the wrong pretext to manage its Tibet policy, and as the government has said, where the Dalai Lama goes within India is a sovereign issue. However, the bigger error may be for the government to be using Tibetan refugees in India as a card in its relations with China.

Deteriorating ties

To begin with, ties between New Delhi and Beijing have deteriorated over the past few years for a number of reasons unconnected to the Dalai Lama and the Tibetan population in India: border incursions, including the standoff at the part of Doklam claimed by Bhutan; India's strategic shift in line with the U.S.'s Indo-Pacific pivot that targets China; China's "deep-pocket" forays into South Asia; and differences on the international stage, including over the Nuclear Suppliers Group membership and terror designations to Masood Azhar. It would be simplistic to assume that these problems would go away if India were to

make the Tibetan community and its leader less visible. Therefore, while it is a mistake to play every visit of the Dalai Lama or official meeting with the leader of the Tibetan government-in-exile, Lobsang Sangay, as a 'challenge to China', it is equally ridiculous to portray strictures on their activities as a 'peace offering to Beijing'.

Second, while Indian strategists have handed down the idea of a Tibet card for decades, it is time to revise this policy with a thorough evaluation of the ground, from New Delhi to Beijing and Lhasa to Dharamshala. For starters, the landscape of Tibet, now crisscrossed with railway lines, super-speed highways, tunnels and airports, has changed drastically in the past two decades. While many have written about the Beijing-Lhasa railway line, the Tibet Autonomous Region (TAR) now sees many more such engineering marvels (orbit at the cost of its environment, and downsize Lhasa has all the trappings of a modern city. All of this has made Tibet more self-reliant, with more jobs for the next generation. There's an ongoing demographic shift in Tibet, with Beijing populating areas with majority Han Chinese workers, encouraging mixed marriages, and mainstreaming Chinese culture into the region. At the same time, the outflow of refugees from Tibet has been curtailed by the Chinese authorities over the last decade, mainly by convincing Nepal to close a popular route. As a result, the number of new arrivals from Tibet into Dharamshala is down to a trickle and the once bustling informal trade route between India and Tibet has also dried up. Bollywood DVDs, once easily available in Lhasa's bustling markets, have been replaced by Chinese and Tibetan films.

The new reality means that India's population of the 100,000 or



so registered Tibetan refugees are more cut off from developments in their homeland than ever before. New generations of Tibetans born in India are brought up as exiles, without a real sense of what Tibet may actually be like, should they ever return. As most live separately in about 40 settlements around India, they also have a tenuous link to the host country itself. The government's attitude towards giving them citizenship has been stern, although it lost its case in the Delhi High Court (Nangyal Dolkar v. Government of India) and must give citizenship to all Tibetan refugees born between 1950 and 1987, the cut-off year. It will be equally important to devise a mechanism for those born after 1987, many now in their twenties, living in this limbo.

The bigger question that looms over the community is that of its future leadership. During his lifetime, the Dalai Lama has been a unifying force, guiding the community through their struggle in a peaceful manner, while accepting an autonomous Tibet as a part of China. While his spiritual incarnation will be chosen through a religious process, his political successor presents a more difficult task — he or she needs to be both

groomed and publicly presented to the community at the earliest. The Dalai Lama himself has retained an air of mystery on the subject, suggesting at different times that his successor may be a woman, one born in a "free" land, or there may be none at all. Another possible leader, Gyen Trinley Dorje, recognised by the Dalai Lama as the head of the Karma Kagyu sect after he escaped to Dharamshala in 2000, has been abroad for the past year. A cryptic message from his office says he will remain in the U.S. for "rest and recovery" from undisclosed "health concerns", with no word on when he may return to India. The Central Tibetan Administration (CTA), which is empowered to run affairs and is headed by the Sangay, may be the more democratic option, but it will need to carry the entire community with it. For the moment, the CTA is following a "live-50" path, to pursue talks with China in the next five years, while committing to a struggle for a more autonomous Tibet in the next 50 years. However, the past few years have seen a rise in the younger and more radical "Rangzen" (freedom) groups that say they will settle for nothing short of an independent Tibet.

As a result, the government's misgivings about officials attending the "Thank You, India" events with the Dalai Lama are minor compared to worries about the more restive Tibetan Youth Congress's "Bhutan Jagran Yatra", with rallies in several cities across the country to "raise awareness for a free Tibet". In his lifetime, there is no question that the Dalai Lama holds sway over the whole community; after him, the direction the community takes will be of vital interest to India as well.

Of equal interest are possible talks between the Dalai Lama and the Chinese government. Reports that the Dalai Lama's special emissary, Samdhong Kempoche, travelled to Yunnan last year have fuelled rumours that the Dalai Lama is preparing to re-enter talks with China, that were dropped in 2010. Chinese President Xi Jinping, who has now secured his position for the foreseeable future, may well take a more proactive interest in the Tibet issue, which his father once discussed with the Dalai Lama.

Ground realities

In short, the idea that India holds the "Tibet card" is out of step with all the shifts on the ground, and the government needs a proactive policy that takes into account these new realities. There is an urgent need for community outreach, surveys and a referendum, if necessary, to map what the Tibetan community in India wants in its future. For those who want to make India a permanent home, especially those in the new generation, India must reconsider its citizenship laws. Above all, the Indian foreign policy establishment needs to stop seeing the Tibetan population in India as a strategic tool.

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Giving up on a statesman

Dalai Lama has won many hearts, including in China. India's decision to shun him reflects poorly on Delhi



RAJMOHAN GANDHI

OFFICIAL INDIAN DECISION to disavow itself from the Dalai Lama, and in apparent keenness to underscore the disavowal, speak of our fallen times. The market and power are our gods, and in Indian elections, there is no "Tibetan constituency" to worry about.

We will, of course, continue to shelter the Dalai Lama and his fellow Tibetans. After all, they were driven out of their homes just north of us 59 years ago, and as neighbours it was our duty to welcome them. Not that we are lenient to shelter all who are driven out of homes near our borders. The Rohingyas? No, sir, although our minds might change if they perform an appropriate *ghar impati*. If they acknowledge that their ancestors a thousand years ago were "Hindus", and if they are willing to be purified and restored to that pristine category, they might become eligible, through a process of what US President Donald Trump would call "extreme vetting", for entry and a carefully watched stay.

His Holiness was entirely different. He was a living Buddha, an incarnation of *Avakiteswara*. Tibetans and Indians revered him. Escaping across the Himalayas with fellow Tibetans, he arrived in India at the age of 24 and was warmly greeted by official and unofficial India. The Dalai Lama and other Tibetans found space in Indian hearts and on India's soil.

Though he was keen on friendship with China, Jawaharlal Nehru, India's prime minister from 1947 to 1964, had no hesitation in welcoming the young Dalai Lama and his associates. Humanity demanded a courteous reception, as did history.

Since then, India's governments of different hues have followed Nehru and consistently taken the position that hosting a revered personality and other Tibetan refugees has nothing to do with being anti-China. Humanitarian gestures and respect for a globally-admired personality should not be seen in political terms.

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India's governments of different hues have followed Nehru and consistently taken the position that hosting a revered personality and other Tibetan refugees has nothing to do with being anti-China. Humanitarian gestures and respect for a globally-admired personality should not be seen in political terms. The stance was, no doubt, tricky, and Beijing was irritated by India's stand. But India's ministers and officials — citizens as well — learnt to comprehend the separate requirements of diplomacy and humanity.

Beijing was irritated by India's stand. But India's ministers and officials — citizens as well — learnt to comprehend the separate requirements of diplomacy and humanity. A powerful factor enabling India's governments and people to adhere to the delicate position was the Dalai Lama himself. His personality, which from the start was sparkling and positive, seemed year-by-year to grow in stature and wisdom. No one meeting, hearing or reading him could easily resist its impact. The Dalai Lama seemed interested in everyone he encountered, always listening, always reflecting on a visitor's questions, always trying to enter into the visitor's situation, always offering suggestions that seemed both practical and elevating.

To have lived like this year after year, and in place after place, for virtually six decades after being forced to flee his homeland remains an astonishing achievement. He spent times with people of different kinds but no crude or mean remark left his lips. He appeared to perform ungracious acts but he was a life of merriment, but a spirit that made him steadily more cheerful, not more solemn.

But he was more than a spiritual pilgrim. Like it or not, the Dalai Lama is the symbol and leader, temporal and spiritual, of a precious group of people who identify themselves with a particular part of our earth, Tibet. In living the political part of his persona, too, the Dalai Lama has displayed statesmanlike qualities, including flexibility and pragmatism.

In recent years, he has spoken unambiguously of his willingness to see Tibet remain a part and province of China if Tibetans are allowed the freedom to exercise cultural and religious autonomy. A report informs what he reiterated this stand as recently as on March 16, when he declared: "Since 1974 we decided not to seek independence. So now [we have been taking] a Middle Way Approach. Common interest is more important than one's own national interest. With that kind of concept, I am very much

willing to remain within the People's Republic of China. Living within the People's Republic of China, we can help [the people of China]."

That Beijing's leaders have been unable to grasp the Dalai Lama's gallant hand of friendship has been a great Asian tragedy, extending Tibetan sorrow but also hurting China's global standing. Detached reflection might inform Beijing that in the Dalai Lama and the Tibetans it possesses a potential bridge to India and the rest of the world that could prove significant. Moreover, at a time when by its own statements the government of China is having to punish corruption on a larger scale, the Dalai Lama's ability to offer deeper goals to the individual suggests his relevance for the people of China.

China's paramount leader Xi Jinping is 38 years younger than the Dalai Lama. Xi is party secretary, state president, and military chief. In recent weeks, his position has been fortified by party resolutions and constitutional amendments. Xi is currently the unchallenged head of what in some ways may be the world's strongest country, even if it contains potential tensions, stronger even than the US, apart from also being the most populous land.

Tenzin Gyatso, on the other hand, the 14th Dalai Lama, leads a tiny fraction of that population, from outside the country, much of that time from India, and all of the time through the quality of his personality and the prestige, descending from history, of the Dalai Lama's position, not by means of any state or party machinery or by guns.

If official India has now explicitly chosen to shun the humblest man, it is not a decision that posterity will necessarily applaud, nor one that a future India will be proud of. For Tenzin Gyatso, through his life-long tapasya, has earned a firm place in the hearts of humanity, including many Chinese hearts. Any setback from exclusion will not be his.

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3 Tibet is not a card

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3 Giving up on a statesman

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We will, of course, continue to shelter the Dalai Lama and his fellow Tibetans. After all, they were driven out of their homes just north of us 59 years ago, and as neighbours it was our duty to welcome them. Not that we are keen to shelter all who are driven out of homes near our borders. The Rohingya? No, sir, although our minds might change if they perform an appropriate ghar wapasi. If they acknowledge that their ancestors a thousand years ago were "Hindus", and if they are willing to be purified and restored to that pristine category, they might become eligible, through a process of what US President Donald Trump would call "extreme vetting", for entry and a carefully watched stay.

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SUHASINGH DAIDAR

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UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... India and its Neighborhood-relations.

DALAI LAMA AND 60 YEARS IN INDIA



During the past 59 years, India learnt to comprehend the separate requirements of diplomacy and humanity.

- 1** Dalai Lama and his followers were driven out of their homes around 59 years ago.
- 2** The original name of 14th Dalai Lama is Tenzin Gyatso. They are of the Gelug School, the newest school of Tibetan Buddhism.
- 3** He is considered as a “Living Buddha”, an incarnation of Avalokiteswara.
- 4** He came to India at the age of 24.
- 5** Jawaharlal Nehru, India’s first Prime Minister, was no hesitation in welcoming the young Dalai Lama.



AFGHANISTAN

JAMMU AND KASHMIR

CHINA

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DALAI LAMA ... FLEXIBILITY & PRAGMATISM

- 1** In recent times, he has spoken unambiguously of his willingness to see Tibet remain a part and province of China, if Tibetans are allowed the freedom to exercise cultural and religious autonomy.
- 2** In his own words, “since 1974, we decided not to seek independence, we want a Middle Way Approach”.
- 3** He also said, “We are willing to remain within the People’s Republic of China”.

The Govt. maintained delicate balance between diplomacy and humanity.

BUT, WHAT IS THE CHANGE SEEN IN RECENT TIMES?



- 1 Govt. issued memo to officials telling them to stay away from events that commemorate the 60th anniversary of the Dalai Lama's 1959 flight to India.
- 2 Several public events relating to Tibet were cancelled.
- 3 There is a perception that Govt. is attempting to appease China by giving up its "Tibet Card".



MONGOLIA

CHINA

TIBET

NEPAL

INDIA

MYANMAR
(BURMA)

VIETNAM

Lao PDR

North Korea

South Korea

JAPAN

Sea of Japan

East China Sea

North Pacific Ocean

BUT, WHAT ARE THE MAIN REASONS FOR DETERIORATING TIES BETWEEN INDIA & CHINA?



- Border incursions.
- Standoff at the part of Doklam area claimed by Bhutan.
- India's strategic shift in line with the U.S.'s Indo-Pacific pivot.
- China's 'deep-pocket' inroads into South Asia.
- China's objection to NSG membership for India.
- China's objection for terror designation to Masood Azhar.

BUT, WHAT CHANGED IN RECENT DECADES?



- 1 Landscape of Tibet has already been changed, Tibet is now crisscrossed with railway lines, super-speed highways, tunnels and airports.
- 2 Several engineering marvels like Beijing-Lhasa railway line along with others are crisscrossing Tibet region. Lhasa is now a modern city.
- 3 Now, Tibet is more self-reliant, more jobs for the next generation.
- 4 There is a demographic shift in Tibet, with Beijing populating areas with majority 'Han' Chinese workers. It is encouraging mixed marriages, it is mainstreaming Chinese culture into the region.

OUTFLOW OF REFUGEES ... CURTAILED BY CHINA



- 1 Outflow of refugees from Tibet have been curtailed by the Chinese authorities.
- 2 It convinced Nepal to close a popular route. Because of this, number of new arrivals from Tibet into Dharamshala are now negligible.

Bollywood DVDs, once available in Lhasa's bustling markets are replaced by Chinese and Tibetan films.



WHAT IS THE REALITY OF THE TIBETAN POPULATION IN INDIA?



- 1 There are 1 lakh or so registered Tibetan refugees in India.
- 2 They are cut-off from the developments in their homeland.
- 3 Most live separately in about 40 settlements around India.
- 4 New generation of Tibetans, who are in 20s, do not have real sense of what Tibet may actually be like.



WHAT IS THE REALITY OF THE TIBETAN POPULATION IN INDIA?



- 5 There is also a dilemma for the younger population, whether to go back or not.
- 6 India lost a case with regard to citizenship in Delhi High Court and must give citizenship to all Tibetan refugees born between 1950 and 1987, the cut-off year.

It is also important to devise a mechanism for those born after 1987.

WHAT ABOUT SUCCESSOR TO DALAI LAMA?



Ogyen Trinley Dorje

- 1 There is air of mystery on the subject. At different times it was suggested that his successor may be a woman, one born in a “free” land, or there may be none at all.
- 2 Another possible leader, Ogyen Trinley Dorje, recognised by the Dalai Lama as the head of the Karma Kagyu sect after he escaped to Dharamshala in 2000, has been abroad for the past one year.

He will remain in the U.S. for rest and recovery from undisclosed health concerns.

WHAT ABOUT CENTRAL TIBETAN ADMINISTRATION (CTA)?



- 1 It is empowered to run the affairs, it is headed by Mr. Sangay.
- 2 It needs to carry the entire community with it.
- 3 It is following a “five-50” path, the meaning is to pursue talks with China in the next five years, at the same time, committing to a struggle for a more autonomous Tibet in the next 50 years.

WHAT ABOUT THE RADICAL GROUPS LIKE “RANGTSEN”?



- 1 For the past few years, there is a raise in the younger and more radical Rangtsen groups, which says that they will settle for nothing short of an independent Tibet.
- 2 There are more restive Tibetan Youth Congress's “Bharat Jagran Yatra”, with rallies in several cities across the country to “raise awareness for a free Tibet”.

In his lifetime, there is no question that the Dalai Lama will hold sway over the whole community. Moreover, after him the direction, the community takes will be of vital interest for India as well.

FINALLY, WHAT CAN WE CONCLUDE?



1 Now, the idea that India holds the “Tibet Card” is totally out of step with the shift on the ground.

2 The Govt. needs a proactive policy that takes into account these new realities.

3 There is an urgent need for community outreach, surveys and referendum, to know what the Tibetan community in India wants for their future.

4 For those who want to make India a permanent home, especially the new generation people, India must reconsider its citizenship laws.

Indian foreign policy establishment should stop seeing the Tibetan population in India as a strategic tool.

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